L3 LEA · S5 NORA VOUTEAU LLF5J30

*Civilisation britannique : the UK since 1945*

# British civilisation: the United Kingdom since 1945 - explained workbook

VERSION EXPRESS · UN EXERCICE D'APPLICATION PAR CHAPITRE

6 · 6 EXERCISES

Exercices rédigés pour l'application à partir des fiches du cours ; les situations marquées « fictive » sont inventées. En cas de différence avec le cours de l'enseignant, c'est le cours qui fait foi.

PART 1

## British institutions: who does what?

**EXERCISE 1.1** APPLICATION FICTIONAL SITUATION

### First past the post in action: votes versus seats

***Objective :*** *Calculate a fictional election result to see how first past the post amplifies some parties and penalises others.*

In an imaginary region with five constituencies of 10,000 voters each, three parties stand: Party X (votes evenly spread), Party Y (very strong in one constituency) and Party Z (a third party whose votes are spread thinly). The results are given below. The rules are those of a British general election.

| CONSTITUENCY | PARTY X | PARTY Y | PARTY Z | TOTAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | 4,000 | 3,500 | 2,500 | 10,000 |
| B | 4,000 | 3,600 | 2,400 | 10,000 |
| C | 4,000 | 3,400 | 2,600 | 10,000 |
| D | 2,500 | 5,500 | 2,000 | 10,000 |
| E | 3,500 | 3,300 | 3,200 | 10,000 |

**Questions**

1. Who wins each constituency? In which constituency is the winner elected without an absolute majority?
2. Calculate each party's total votes and share of the vote.
3. Calculate each party's number of seats and share of the seats.
4. Comment on the result: which party is the big winner, which is the big loser, and why?
5. Using the course, explain why this system tends to produce a two-party system in Britain, and why the SNP is an exception.

PART 2

## Building the Welfare State (1942-1951)

EXERCISE 2.1 APPLICATION

## Completing the timeline of the Attlee years

***Objective :*** *Put the founding measures of the Welfare State and the nationalisations in chronological order and understand what each of them changed.*

The timeline below has gaps. Complete it using the reminder and your course, then answer the questions.

| DATE | EVENT OR MEASURE |
|---|---|
| December 1942 | ..... (author: .....) |
| 1944 | Education Act (Butler): ..... |
| July 1945 | ..... |
| 1946 | National Insurance Act; .....; nationalisation of the ..... and of civil aviation |
| 1947 | Nationalisation of ..... (National Coal Board) |
| 5 July 1948 | ..... (Minister: .....) |
| 1948 | National Assistance Act; nationalisation of ..... and ..... |
| 1949 | Nationalisation of ..... |
| 1951 | Nationalisation of ..... |

**Questions**

1. Complete the timeline.
2. Classify the measures into 'social' and 'economic' measures.
3. Why is iron and steel a good example of the alternation of power in British politics?
4. What were the aims of nationalisation, and what is a 'mixed economy'?

PART 3

# Consensus, decline and the crisis of the 1970s

EXERCISE 3.1 APPLICATION

## Stop-go and the European question: putting things in order

***Objective :*** *Reconstruct the logic of the stop-go cycle and the stages of Britain's late entry into Europe.*

Part A: the five stages of the stop-go cycle are jumbled: (a) pressure on sterling; (b) slowdown and unemployment, then a new expansion; (c) demand is boosted by tax cuts and credit; (d) restraint: higher interest rates and credit restrictions; (e) rising imports, inflation and an external deficit. Part B: match the dates 1957, 1960, 1963, 1973, 1975 with the following events: EFTA founded; accession to the European Community under Heath; EEC turned down; referendum on staying in; first veto by de Gaulle.

**Questions**

1. Put the stages of the stop-go cycle in the right order and explain each link.
2. Why does stop-go illustrate the idea of 'relative decline'?
3. Match the dates and the events of Part B.
4. Why did Britain join the European Community so late?

PART 4

## Thatcherism (1979-1990)

**EXERCISE 4.1** APPLICATION

### A Thatcherite timeline and the aims of privatisation

***Objective :*** *Order the main measures and events of the Thatcher years and explain the political aims of privatisation.*

You are preparing revision cards. Place the following items on a timeline from 1979 to 1990: Right to Buy; British Telecom privatised; Big Bang; miners' strike; poll tax introduced in England and Wales; Thatcher's resignation; abolition of exchange controls; British Gas privatised ('Tell Sid'); Trafalgar Square riot; British Airways and Rolls-Royce privatised.

**Questions**

1. Draw the timeline with the date of each item.
2. What were the aims of privatisation? Explain the expressions 'popular capitalism' and 'property-owning democracy'.
3. Give two arguments in favour of privatisation and two criticisms, as presented in the course.

PART 5

## From Major to New Labour (1990-2007)

**EXERCISE 5.1** APPLICATION

### The years 1992-1998: a timeline and the Good Friday Agreement

***Objective :*** *Order the key events from Black Wednesday to the Good Friday Agreement and explain the main principles of the Agreement.*

Complete the table, then answer the questions on the Good Friday Agreement.

| DATE | EVENT | PRIME MINISTER |
|---|---|---|
| 16 September 1992 | ..... | ..... |
| 1993 | Ratification of ..... with opt-outs; Downing Street Declaration | ..... |
| 1995 | ..... | (Labour leader: .....) |
| 1 May 1997 | ..... | ..... |
| 1997 | Independence of the ..... over monetary policy | ..... |
| 10 April 1998 | ..... | ..... |
| 22 May 1998 | ..... | ..... |
| 1999 | First elections to the ..... | ..... |

**Questions**

1. Complete the table.
2. Explain why Black Wednesday weakened the Conservatives.
3. Explain three principles of the Good Friday Agreement.
4. Why did the Irish border become an issue in the Brexit negotiations?

PART 6

## Method: the document commentary and the essay

**EXERCISE 6.1** APPLICATION FICTIONAL SITUATION

### Building a commentary plan for a 1997 campaign speech

***Objective :*** *Go from a document to a central question and a thematic plan, using course knowledge.*

Document (fictional): an extract from a speech delivered in April 1997 by an imaginary Labour candidate, Sarah Lennox, at a meeting in Glasgow during the general election campaign. She declares: 'We will not go back to the old ways of nationalisation. But we will give every worker a fair minimum wage, and we will give Scotland its own Parliament.' She attacks 'eighteen years of Conservative government' and the 'humiliation of Black Wednesday'.

**Questions**

1. Explain the five underlined references with your course knowledge.
2. Formulate a central question.
3. Propose a thematic plan in three parts.
4. Write the conclusion, with an opening.

# Explained answer key

## Exercise 1.1 · First past the post in action: votes versus seats

1. 1. A: X (4,000); B: X (4,000); C: X (4,000); D: Y (5,500); E: X (3,500). In E, X wins with only 35% of the votes (3,500 out of 10,000): there is no absolute majority, but under first past the post coming first is enough. In A, B and C, X also wins with 40%, again without an absolute majority.
2. 2. X: 4,000 x 3 + 2,500 + 3,500 = 18,000 votes, i.e. 18,000 / 50,000 = 36%. Y: 3,500 + 3,600 + 3,400 + 5,500 + 3,300 = 19,300 votes, i.e. 38.6%. Z: 2,500 + 2,400 + 2,600 + 2,000 + 3,200 = 12,700 votes, i.e. 25.4%. Check: 18,000 + 19,300 + 12,700 = 50,000.
3. 3. X: 4 seats out of 5 = 80%. Y: 1 seat = 20%. Z: 0 seats = 0%.
4. 4. X is the big winner: with 36% of the votes it gets 80% of the seats, because its votes are spread efficiently, just enough to come first almost everywhere. Y actually wins the most votes (38.6%) but only one seat: many of its votes are 'wasted' in D, where it piles up a huge lead, and it comes second elsewhere. Z is the big loser: a quarter of the votes and no seat at all, because it comes third everywhere. This is the amplifying effect of the plurality system: it often produces a clear majority on a minority of the vote.
5. 5. Because only first place counts, voters and resources concentrate on the two parties that can win locally, the Conservatives and Labour; parties whose votes are spread thinly (Liberal Democrats, Reform UK, Greens) win few seats, like Z. A party whose votes are concentrated in one area, like the SNP in Scotland, can come first in many constituencies there and win many seats, a little like Y in constituency D. The course adds that a 2011 referendum rejected a switch to the Alternative Vote.
6. Final result: X 36% of votes / 80% of seats; Y 38.6% / 20%; Z 25.4% / 0%.

**Traps to avoid :** Believing an MP needs an absolute majority (over 50%) to be elected. · Assuming that the party with the most votes overall necessarily wins the most seats. · Forgetting to check that the vote totals add up to 50,000.

## Exercise 2.1 · Completing the timeline of the Attlee years

1. 1. December 1942: Beveridge Report, 'Social Insurance and Allied Services' (William Beveridge). 1944: Education Act, free secondary education. July 1945: Labour victory, Clement Attlee becomes Prime Minister. 1946: National Insurance Act; National Health Service Act; nationalisation of the Bank of England and of civil aviation. 1947: coal. 5 July 1948: launch of the NHS (Aneurin Bevan). 1948: National Assistance Act; railways and transport, electricity. 1949: gas. 1951: iron and steel.
2. 2. Social: Beveridge Report, Education Act 1944, National Insurance Act, NHS Act and launch of the NHS, National Assistance Act. Economic: the nationalisations of 1946 to 1951.
3. 3. Iron and steel was nationalised by Labour in 1951, denationalised by the Conservatives in 1953, then renationalised by Labour in 1967. Each change of majority at Westminster brought a change of ownership: since Parliament is sovereign, a new majority can repeal what the previous one did. It also shows that the consensus had limits: most nationalisations were kept, but steel remained a point of disagreement.
4. 4. In line with Clause IV of the Labour constitution (common ownership of the means of production), the aims were to modernise ageing industries, guarantee employment and plan reconstruction in strategic or failing sectors. A mixed economy is one where a public sector (here about a fifth of the economy) coexists with a private sector.
5. Final result: between 1942 and 1951, Britain moved from a report to a complete system of social protection and a mixed economy.

**Traps to avoid :** Dating the NHS to 1946: 1946 is the Act, 1948 the launch. · Thinking that all nationalisations happened in 1945. · Forgetting the denationalisation of steel in 1953.

## Exercise 3.1 · Stop-go and the European question: putting things in order

1. 1. c -> e -> a -> d -> b. Go: the government boosts demand (c). Demand attracts imports and pushes prices up, creating inflation and a balance-of-payments deficit (e). This deficit weakens sterling (a). To defend the pound, the government imposes restraint (d): this is the 'stop'. The economy slows down and unemployment rises, after which a new expansion begins (b).
2. 2. The cycle prevents steady growth: each expansion is interrupted before it can bear fruit. Britain therefore grows, but more slowly than West Germany, France or Japan: this is relative decline, not absolute impoverishment. The devaluations of 1949 and 1967 show the weakness of sterling.
3. 3. 1957: EEC turned down. 1960: EFTA founded. 1963: first veto by de Gaulle (against the 1961 application). 1973: accession on 1 January under Heath, with Ireland and Denmark. 1975: referendum in June, about 67% for staying in.
4. 4. Britain gave priority to the Commonwealth, to its special relationship with the United States and to its sovereignty, so it refused the ECSC and the EEC. When it saw the dynamism of the EEC, it applied in 1961 (Macmillan) and 1967 (Wilson), but General de Gaulle vetoed both applications. It only joined in 1973.
5. Final result: Part A order c-e-a-d-b; Part B 1957 EEC refused, 1960 EFTA, 1963 veto, 1973 accession, 1975 referendum.

**Traps to avoid :** Confusing the 1975 referendum (Yes to staying in) with the 2016 referendum (Leave). · Saying that Britain was absent from Europe until 1973 because of its own refusal only: the vetoes matter too. · Confusing relative decline with absolute impoverishment.

## Exercise 4.1 · A Thatcherite timeline and the aims of privatisation

1. 1. 1979: abolition of exchange controls. 1980: Right to Buy (Housing Act). 1984: British Telecom; March 1984 - March 1985: miners' strike. 1986: British Gas ('Tell Sid'); 27 October 1986: Big Bang. 1987: British Airways and Rolls-Royce. 31 March 1990: Trafalgar Square riot against the poll tax; April 1990: poll tax in England and Wales. November 1990: Thatcher resigns.
2. 2. Aims: efficiency through competition and profit; revenue for the state; reduced trade union influence in the public corporations; and 'popular capitalism', i.e. spreading share ownership among ordinary citizens (advertising campaigns such as 'Tell Sid'). 'Property-owning democracy' follows the same logic for housing: with Right to Buy, council tenants could buy their homes and become owners.
3. 3. For: efficiency gains in some sectors; revenue for the state. Against: share ownership became concentrated again; price rises; private monopolies that required regulators.
4. Final result: privatisation was both an economic and a political project, meant to change the relationship between citizens, the state and property.

**Traps to avoid :** Dating the poll tax in England to 1989: 1989 is Scotland. · Forgetting that Right to Buy concerns housing, not a company.

## Exercise 5.1 · The years 1992-1998: a timeline and the Good Friday Agreement

1. 1. 16 September 1992: Black Wednesday, sterling leaves the European Exchange Rate Mechanism (Major). 1993: Maastricht, Downing Street Declaration (Major). 1995: Clause IV rewritten (Tony Blair). 1 May 1997: New Labour landslide (Blair). 1997: Bank of England independence (Blair). 10 April 1998: signature of the Good Friday Agreement (Blair). 22 May 1998: approval by referendum in Northern Ireland and in the Republic of Ireland (Blair). 1999: Scottish Parliament and Welsh Assembly (Blair).
2. 2. Under speculative attack, the pound had to leave the European Exchange Rate Mechanism: the Conservatives' economic credibility collapsed, even though growth later returned. Added to divisions over Maastricht and sleaze, this prepared the 1997 defeat.
3. 3. Principle of consent: Northern Ireland remains British for as long as a majority of its population wishes. Power-sharing: the Assembly and Executive bring together unionists and nationalists. Cooperation: North-South bodies and a British-Irish Council. Also: decommissioning of paramilitary weapons and early release of prisoners.
4. 4. Northern Ireland is part of the United Kingdom, while the Republic of Ireland is an independent state and a member of the EU. When the United Kingdom left the EU, the border between the two became an external EU border, which threatened the open cooperation built by the Agreement.
5. Final result: 1992-1997 shows the Conservatives losing credibility; 1997-1998 shows New Labour's reforms and the peace process.

**Traps to avoid :** Attributing the Good Friday Agreement to Major: he launched the peace process (1993), Blair's government signed the Agreement. · Confusing the exit from the Exchange Rate Mechanism (1992) with the exit from the EU (2020). · Confusing Northern Ireland and the Republic of Ireland.

## Exercise 6.1 · Building a commentary plan for a 1997 campaign speech

1. 1. 'Old ways of nationalisation': Clause IV (common ownership), rewritten by Blair in 1995; New Labour refuses to renationalise. 'Minimum wage': the national minimum wage, created in 1998. 'Scotland its own Parliament': devolution, the referendum of September 1997 and the Scotland Act 1998. 'Eighteen years of Conservative government': from Thatcher's victory in May 1979 to 1997 (Thatcher then Major). 'Black Wednesday': 16 September 1992, sterling leaves the European Exchange Rate Mechanism and the Conservatives lose their economic credibility.
2. 2. Possible central question: How does this speech reflect New Labour's attempt to combine a break with Old Labour and an alternative to Conservative rule?
3. 3. I. A modernised Labour Party: no return to nationalisation, acceptance of the market (the Third Way). II. A programme of social justice and constitutional reform: minimum wage, Scottish Parliament; the choice of Glasgow shows the speech targets Scottish voters. III. An attack on a worn-out government: eighteen years in power, Black Wednesday; but the speaker is silent on what New Labour keeps from Thatcherism, a limit to point out.
4. 4. Model conclusion: This speech thus sheds light on the New Labour synthesis of market economics and social reform, which helped win the landslide of 1 May 1997. Its promises were kept: the national minimum wage and the Scotland Act both date from 1998, and the Scottish Parliament was elected in 1999. Yet devolution did not extinguish Scottish nationalism, as the 2014 independence referendum would show.
5. Final result: a document becomes a commentary when each reference is explained, grouped by theme and placed in a longer history.

**Traps to avoid :** Following the order of the text line by line. · Forgetting the critical part: what the speaker does not say. · Ending without an opening.

*Ouverture du journal…*